

Copywriting for Business: Beginner's Guide

Lesson 4: Writing Headlines That Grab Attention

Writing Headlines That Grab Attention – Study Notes

Key Concepts

1. **Headline Formulas** – Ready made structures that can be filled in with your own details.
2. **Benefit Driven Language** – Focus on what the reader **gains** (savings, speed, exclusivity).
3. **Urgency & Scarcity** – Words that create a “now or never” feeling.
4. **Specificity & Numbers** – Concrete figures make a headline more credible and eye catching.
5. **Testing & Tweaking** – Use A/B tests or quick mental checks to see which headline performs best.

Summary

A headline is the first (and sometimes only) chance to convince a shopper to keep reading. By using proven formulas—such as “X% Off + Product + Reason” or “How to + Desired Result in Y Time”—you can instantly communicate value, spark curiosity, and drive clicks.

For e-commerce sales, the most effective headlines combine a clear benefit (discount, free gift, limited stock) with urgency (“today only”) and specificity (exact percentages, dollar amounts, or quantities). After drafting several options, test them with real users or split testing tools; the winning headline will usually have the highest open rate or click through rate.

Important Points

- **Keep it short:** 6–10 words (“H 60 characters) works best for most platforms.
- **Lead with the biggest hook:** discount, free item, or limited time offer.
- **Use power words:** “instant,” “exclusive,” “secret,” “proven,” “save.”
- **Add a time cue:** “Today,” “24 Hour,” “Ends Midnight.”
- **Include numbers:** “30%,” “\$20,” “3 Day,” “5 Step.”
- **Match tone to brand:** playful for a youthful brand, professional for luxury.
- **Test at least two variants:** change one element (e.g., % vs \$\$) to see impact.
- **Avoid click bait:** the promise must be fulfilled in the copy/product.

Examples

Example 1 – Flash Sale

Headline: “40% Off All Sneakers – 24 Hour Flash Deal!”

Why it works:

- **Benefit:** 40% discount (big saving).

- **Urgency:** “24 Hour Flash Deal” tells the reader they must act now.
- **Specificity:** Exact percentage and product category.
- **Visual cue:** Emoji adds eye catching flair without clutter.

Example 2 – Free Gift Offer

Headline: “Buy One, Get a \$15 Gift Card – Today Only!”

Why it works:

- **Benefit:** Immediate \$15 value added to the purchase.
- **Scarcity:** “Today Only” creates a deadline.
- **Clarity:** Simple “Buy One, Get” structure is easy to understand at a glance.

(Both headlines can be A/B tested on the homepage banner; whichever yields a higher click through rate becomes the primary headline.)

Quick Review

1. **What are two key ingredients that make a headline urgent?**
2. **Name three power words you could use in an e commerce headline.**
3. **Why is it important to include numbers in a headline?**
4. **List the steps you would take to test a new headline.**
5. **Give an example of a headline formula and fill it in for a summer clothing sale.**

Further Reading

- Copywriting formulas: “The 4U’s” (Useful, Urgent, Unique, Ultra specific)
- Psychological triggers in marketing (scarcity, reciprocity, social proof)
- A/B testing best practices for e commerce sites
- Mobile first headline design (character limits, emoji usage)
- Advanced headline analysis with tools like CoSchedule Headline Analyzer.

